

Episode 161: Long Ago... 100 1995 Part 19 Theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS* and Various Thoughts October and November

I hate nuclear power plants. I hate them, but it's fact that nuclear power plants are one of the major pillars supporting the massive electrical situation for us Tokyo residents and the metropolitan area. And due to earthquake accidents, Fukushima's nuclear power plants are now in terrible situations, with radiation danger approaching Fukushima Prefecture residents and us metropolitan area residents. The government keeps repeating "it's safe," but online "danger!" is being shouted, and everyone lives with anxiety.

I'm not an expert so I'm not in a position to say "which is correct," but it's inescapable fact that unpleasant situations are approaching. For now, staying in Tokyo seems OK, but quite a number of people want to leave Tokyo and the metropolitan area. Some among my acquaintances and industry colleagues too.

Rather than "effects on human body," I think it's first about "peace of mind." Particularly for those with small children, infants, pregnant women - there are only anxiety factors. Once you become concerned and anxiety sprouts, those sprouts only grow and won't easily disappear. So for peace of mind too, I think evacuation to other regions is one strategy for those in situations where it's possible.

But the majority, including myself, aren't in such situations. We must continue doing what we can do now, our roles. Various things happen and progress isn't immediate, but steadily advancing step by step is essential. Staying composed without wavering. But never becoming stubborn, constantly recognising new information and surrounding situations. Always preparing and waiting for opportunities.

With such feelings, I'm currently participating in a new TV series at a certain Mitaka studio. I believe society will be somewhat calmer by the time this work can be viewed. Anyway.

Theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS: The 9 Sailor Soldiers Unite! Miracle of the Black Dream Hole* (←title too long (laugh)), the 1996 New Year movie - nationwide release December 23rd, Emperor's Birthday. With always tight Toei Animation production and Toei distribution theatrical work schedules, general previews are held the weekend before release. These principally use prints for general screenings at the venue theatres. So one week before those previews, we complete it tentatively, do a zero preview, and begin printing films for screening.

Print work procedure starts with prints for theatres far from Tokyo that take time to transport. Theatrical screenings use 35mm film, but small rural theatres were still using 16mm film screening then, and I think they started with those 16mm films.

About 1-2 weeks before master completion (negative editing) and zero preview, there's sound work. Music and sound effects. Impact sounds, explosion sounds, effects sounds for special moves, character clothing rustle sounds, etc. Furthermore, whether sounds come from right, left, front, back, or while moving - sound positioning matches screen movement. So naturally, screens must be completed to add those sound effects.

Editing to adjust acting timing and determine overall movie length was November 11th this time, with voice actors dubbing the next 12th. But screens weren't completed yet. About 1/5 was almost finished at this point - cuts made in advance for trailers and transformation bank cuts also used in TV series. The remaining 4/5 were still rough photography and timing shots (when cels are finished but backgrounds aren't ready or photography effects take time, we temporarily shoot with just cels to understand voice and sound timing).

Anyway, editing and dubbing require minimum rough animation completion for acting, so rough animation gathers for this editing. Animation directors then do intensive animation director work. Next, I add colour direction (色指定) and order in-betweening and finishing. Parallel to colour direction work, inspect finished cels, process retakes, pass to photography, rushes check photographed cuts, and process retakes in parallel if

any. So the approximately 2 weeks from editing and dubbing to sound work are the real crunch. The actual battle.

Theatrical works of this era were all cel production. Moreover, needing creation in short periods, domestic productions usually handling Toei works and Manila studio alone weren't sufficient, so we requested work from Korean and Chinese productions. As I write every time, paint problems arise. Toei works' basic STAC paint versus Korean and Chinese productions' Taiyo Shisai paint. This colour development difference is quite difficult. Particularly *Sailor Moon* requires clear colour development finishing. We want to avoid muddy colours on screen as much as possible. But production-wise, we must also request Taiyo Shisai paint productions. Moreover, volume-wise, during crunch periods, the ratio requested from Korean and Chinese productions inevitably becomes much higher.

Still, this theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS* was my third Sailor Moon. Based on past two works' reflections, I allocated "normal" colour cuts and Sailor Soldier cuts to productions that could use STAC paint as much as possible. Instead, enemy boss character "Badiyanu" and "Bonbon Babies" cuts that seemed OK painted with Taiyo Shisai paint, and background scenes of kidnapped children were priorititionally ordered to Taiyo Shisai productions. Even Sailor Soldiers' special colouring scene cuts were designed from the colour design stage using Taiyo Shisai paint from the start.

This was actually more convenient for me. Character clarity in normal scenes was definitely better with STAC colours, and since TV series used STAC colours, including compatibility with bank scenes also used in TV series, it appeared in familiar balance to audiences coming to theatres. Conversely, night colours, reddish special colouring in Badiyanu's castle battle scenes, and reflection highlights and high contrast colours worked better with subtle colour creation based on Taiyo Shisai paint's rich colour variety. What always concerned me was retake processing after cels were painted with Taiyo Shisai colours, but by this time, considerable Taiyo Shisai paint stock existed in-house, covering most retakes.

Like this, in December. December 13th, exactly 10 days before release, theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS* safely had its zero preview. Somehow completed.

Everything works out somehow if you're properly prepared, no matter how difficult. This theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS* was probably quite difficult including work volume during crunch, but somehow felt like we persevered without much confusion. Well, maybe various things were difficult, but ah, I don't remember...

Like the previous two works, *Sailor Moon* theatrical works involved colour creation and screen creation thinking about first firmly reproducing TV series visual impressions, then how much "theatrical work-ness" could be added on top. I think I managed to work hard well in my own way for this third theatrical version.

But still, detailed areas show roughness throughout the screen. Myself feeling limits and rebelling against this theatrical work creation method of making everything at once in short periods, and myself having experience and familiarity from experiencing such creation methods multiple times yearly. Feeling dilemma about myself lacking clear satisfaction in that gap was also fact. "Not remembering very well" the difficult aspects might also represent becoming accustomed to such theatrical work creation methods. I want to make theatrical works taking more time carefully. But I also understand that's definitely impossible while working at Toei Animation.

"So how should I be within such creation methods?" I began pondering such thoughts around this period.

Though I was like that, there was another reason for "not remembering very well" the difficult aspects... While handling TV series *Neighbourhood Story* colour design in parallel, currently in enthusiastic crunch for theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS*. And amazingly, preparation for two more theatrical works plus another different job had started. That was November 1995.

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